

Mission Report: Cave Diving in the Silent Woods

At the crack of dawn, the party—consisting of Orchid, Sedressel, Gaven, and myself—assembled at the guild hall. Amber briefed us on the cave we were tasked to explore, located a two-day journey northeast of Haven within the Silent Woods. Our first day of travel was mostly uneventful, save for a bizarre encounter with a cart full of cabbages that had seemingly plummeted from the sky; they were charred and hot to the touch, so we wisely chose to leave them alone. That night at camp, the sky revealed a strange anomaly—had the moon always had a crack in it? By dusk on the second day, we reached our destination: a cave entrance situated atop a hill in the Silent Forest. We opted to set up camp outside and begin our descent the following morning.

Entering the cave at dawn, we immediately spotted what appeared to be a griffon's nest containing an egg, some scattered bones, and a pile of gold. However, as we approached, the mirage vanished, revealing an illusion cast by a demon known as the Informant. The entity offered a treacherous deal: in exchange for full intelligence on all the dangers ahead, it demanded the current and future knowledge of one party member. We firmly declined, but Orchid attempted to bargain. Despite the party's skepticism, she traded all her past knowledge to learn the location of the "crown piece quest". The demon was pleased with the exchange and granted her the information.

Pressing deeper into the cavern for a few hours, we emerged into a massive subterranean chamber. Before us lay a petrified forest; the trees, grass, and even small animals were composed entirely of solid stone. Our inspection revealed nothing inherently special about the rock itself, leading us to surmise it was the result of a petrifying force—one that even restoration spells would likely fail to reverse. As we navigated the stone woods, we encountered a bull-like beast. Closer inspection revealed it to be a gorgon, which swiftly grew enraged and attacked. We managed to defeat the creature, taking careful measures to avoid its petrifying breath.

Further into the forest, we spotted a massive gate guarded by several stone humanoid figures. Testing their hostility, we fired a warning arrow from a distance, which immediately provoked them into a charging attack. During the ensuing skirmish, Gaven attempted to reach their minds telepathically but received no response, confirming they were not regular living beings. After dismantling the guards, we approached the sturdy gate. Unable to open it conventionally, we used magic to transmute the stone into wood and melted it down with fire. Beyond the gate lay a sprawling underground city, faintly reminiscent of the ruins we previously saw near the Dreglords' domain. Prioritizing our primary investigation, we decided to bypass the city for now and returned to an alternate path we had noticed near the front of the forest.

This secondary path proved drastically different; after a few hours of walking, the cavern walls began to gleam and shine with a divine-like radiance, possibly influenced by the region above ground. Exhausted, we set up camp for the day, but our rest was interrupted just as we began to eat. Two bizarre, cornucopia-like creatures ambushed us, forcefully attempting to feed us. Even after indulging them, they relentlessly tried to force-feed us further, pushing us into a desperate battle. We barely survived the encounter, with Gaven nearly perishing

from overeating and extreme exhaustion. The rest of the night was miserable as we recovered—and threw up—from the ordeal.

On the fourth day, we pressed on and found a fork in the path. One route led upward to the surface, depositing us briefly in the Eastern Woods. We decided to head back down and see where the remaining tunnels led. Returning to the glittering cave, we eventually reached another split. Scouting with our familiars, we discovered that one path led to a large underground lake infested with crocodiles and other aquatic threats, while the other ascended and carried the foul stench of rotting flesh. Avoiding the crocodiles, we took the upward path and soon discovered two humanoid corpses. Based on their burst stomachs and signs of overeating, they had clearly fallen victim to the cornucopia creatures a few days prior. Examining their gear, we suspected they belonged to the New Wings faction, though we could not be completely certain.

Continuing upward for another two hours, we found our exit blocked by a large gate leading to the surface. Our scouting familiars were immediately shot down, revealing a heavily fortified bandit or faction settlement just beyond. Gaven blasted the gate open, exposing a squad of defending soldiers. We noticed a network of strange vents and attempted to shoot them down, but their captain shouted that the cavern was already filled with gas. She threw fire into the area, causing a devastating flash fire that immediately took Sedressel down. Overwhelmed by a sudden flood of heavier reinforcements, Orchid—as the last one standing—was forced to surrender, as the enemy threatened to execute our downed companions if we tried to escape.

We were taken prisoner and brought before their captain, an imposing figure clad in full back armor and wielding specialized gauntlets. She interrogated Orchid regarding the Striders Guild's intelligence on the New Wings. Before eventually releasing us back into the cave, the captain delivered a strict ultimatum to Orchid, warning us never to return to their settlement. The cost of our release, however, was astronomical. They stripped us of all our belongings, leaving us with nothing but a single dagger. Tragically, they murdered Gaven, and in a brutal display of cruelty, severed the hands of both Sedressel and myself. It is a miracle we managed to make it back to Haven with Gaven's body. While we successfully completed the investigation of the cave, a bitter taste remains; we lost our most prized possessions to Haven's enemy, the New Wings.

Report written by Oxyotl